

**DIGITIZATION AND SELF SERVICE: A MISSION TO
IMPROVE SERVICE DELIVERY IN THE UNIVERSITY OF
LAGOS**

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The University of Lagos, like many institutions, faces a growing demand for its support services. Queues at the medical centre persist due to manual record-keeping and the absence of appointment systems, while delays in registration and result access remain common.

These realities reflect the urgent need for smarter systems that align with the pace of modern academic life. In today's digital age, where technology is reshaping how people live and learn, digitization and self-service are essential for improving university services. Thus, this essay examines the concept of digitization and self-service as essential tools in modern service delivery, highlights UNILAG's current strengths, and argues for deeper digital integration to enhance service delivery.

2.0 THE CONCEPT OF DIGITIZATION AND SELF-SERVICE AS ESSENTIAL TOOLS IN MODERN SERVICE DELIVERY

Improving service delivery at the University of Lagos first requires understanding the broader concepts of digitization and self-service in higher education. The Collins Dictionary defines digitization as “the process of transcribing data into a digital form that can be directly processed by a computer” [1]. Simply put, it means converting manual activities into formats more easily managed with technology, such as online registration, e-learning platforms, digital libraries, and electronic records. Closely linked to this is self-service, which allows students and staff to independently complete tasks like course enrolment, payments, or feedback without constant administrative assistance [2].

Digitization and self-service are vital in modern universities because they improve efficiency, ease staff workload, and promote transparency [3]. By enabling routine tasks to be completed faster and giving stakeholders direct access to their information, these tools foster a more accountable academic environment. Globally, universities have already embraced this shift. Harvard University Health Services, for example, provides a portal for scheduling appointments and accessing medical records [4], while the University of London uses Moodle to streamline assignments and grading [5]. These cases show that digitization is not a luxury but a necessity for institutions seeking relevance in the digital age.

Having established the importance of digitization and self-service in higher education, attention now turns to the University of Lagos, where notable progress in digital initiatives reflects an encouraging foundation for further growth.

3.0 THE CURRENT STRENGTHS WITHIN THE UNIVERSITY OF LAGOS

While digitization and self-service are essential to modern universities, it is also important to recognize how the University of Lagos has already embraced these tools in its service delivery.

UNILAG has made notable progress through platforms that improve efficiency across its community. The online registration and portal system allows students to handle enrolment and payments, while easing manual verification for staff. The university's digital library and research databases expand academic resources for both students and faculty, while the General Studies (GST) portal provides video lectures, materials, and assignment submissions. An online test portal further supports digital assessments, making grading faster and more transparent.

Accountability has improved through automated email and SMS alerts after course edits or fee payments, giving users instant confirmation. Security measures include time-based passwords for computer-based tests, while the Microsoft partnership provides matric-number-based accounts that support cloud services, collaboration, and academic work. Beyond academics, the launch of electric buses and Wi-Fi access at designated areas reflect UNILAG's broader commitment to digital innovation and sustainability.

Together, these initiatives show that UNILAG is not only adopting digital practices but also laying the groundwork for more advanced self-service solutions that benefit students, staff, and administrators alike.

Building on these strengths, the discussion now turns to how deeper digital integration can address persistent challenges and improve the overall university experience.

4.0 OPPORTUNITIES FOR ENHANCING SERVICE DELIVERY AT THE UNIVERSITY OF LAGOS

Drawing from these achievements, several opportunities emerge for strengthening service delivery at UNILAG. Key areas include enhancing access to medical centre services, expanding support through virtual tools, creating structured online learning, and strengthening communication between students and administration. Together, these opportunities show how deeper use of digital tools and self-service can transform the university experience for all stakeholders.

4.1 MEDICAL CENTRE ACCESS

One of the critical areas where digitization can enhance service delivery in the University of Lagos is the medical centre. Currently, the centre faces long queues, manual record-keeping, and no appointment system. From personal experience, I once waited over three hours to see a doctor, only for a senior administrative staff member to bypass the queue for a minor service. This reflects the absence of structured scheduling, which creates inefficiency and undermines fairness. By contrast, Harvard University Health Services offers online booking, secure access to personal medical records, and streamlined communication for urgent cases [4]. Thus, adopting a similar digital health portal at UNILAG, where stakeholders can book appointments, view records, and pre-report symptoms, would reduce delays, prioritize emergencies, and ensure more transparent healthcare delivery.

4.2 SUPPORT SERVICES

Another area where digitization can enhance service delivery at UNILAG is access to support services. Students and staff often depend on visiting physical offices for inquiries such as bursary issues, transcript requests, or programme details, which leads to delays and congestion. I was once asked to visit a faculty office on behalf of a colleague to confirm a programme requirement, an errand that could have been avoided with reliable self-service platforms. In many cases, individuals travel long distances or wait for hours just to obtain basic information. By comparison, George Washington University introduced an AI-powered chatbot, “Martha,” to provide round-the-clock assistance for common IT inquiries, reducing staff workload while ensuring quick responses [6]. UNILAG could adopt a similar model

through virtual assistants and self-service portals or kiosks for routine academic and administrative requests. Such systems would improve efficiency, minimize unnecessary visits, and build trust in the accessibility of information.

4.3 STRUCTURED ONLINE LEARNING

A further opportunity for enhancing service delivery at UNILAG is the development of structured online learning. At present, many students rely on external platforms such as Coursera or Udemy, while the university lacks a central hub for certified short courses formally tied to academic records. Informal alternatives, such as WhatsApp tutorials, remain unstructured and disconnected. I had the opportunity to participate in the Soft Skills Training Program organized by ICLED Business School in collaboration with the UNILAG Office of Career Development Services. The initiative was impactful and demonstrated the potential of university-led training when designed in a structured and accessible format. Globally, institutions like Harvard offer certified online programs through platforms such as edX and HarvardX, providing flexible courses that strengthen professional development [7]. Thus, by establishing a digital hub for certificate-based courses open to the public, UNILAG could expand its academic reach, generate new revenue streams, and enhance career opportunities for students and staff.

4.4 COMMUNICATION GAPS

Finally, an important area where digitization can strengthen service delivery in UNILAG is communication between students and administration. At present, information such as timetables, policy updates, or complaint procedures is often fragmented across noticeboards, faculty offices, or informal channels, leading to delays and misinformation. In contrast, Harvard employs centralized digital platforms and mobile apps to deliver real-time updates, ensuring consistent communication across its community [8]. UNILAG could adopt a similar approach by creating a mobile app or centralized hub for official announcements, schedules, and complaints, thereby improving transparency and ensuring stakeholders receive timely and reliable information.

5.0 CONCLUSION

Digitization and self-service are now essential to modern service delivery, and UNILAG has laid a solid foundation through its portals and digital resources. Yet, more can be achieved by addressing key gaps: improving access at the medical centre, expanding virtual support, creating structured online learning, and strengthening communication with students. Embracing these opportunities will not only boost efficiency but also create a more inclusive and responsive university system. Ultimately, pursuing full digitization as a mission for service excellence will position UNILAG as a model of higher education innovation in Nigeria and beyond.

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